

Baby Hippo in Thailand Gets Official Song for Worldwide Fans

A baby hippopotamus in Thailand became famous earlier this year when zoo workers published images and videos of her online. Now the pygmy hippo, named Moo Deng, has an official song and video released in several languages for her fans worldwide.

Moo Deng lives at Khao Kheow Open Zoo, southeast of the Thai capital, Bangkok. Zoo worker Atthapon Nundee has been posting sweet moments of the animal's life for the past few months.

During that time, the hippo has received widespread attention on social media. Fans of the animal have expressed how they enjoy watching the pink-cheeked baby actively interact with her mother and other zoo workers.

Moo Deng – which means “bouncy pork” in Thai – is a kind of meatball. The name, chosen by fans on social media, is similar to those of her two siblings: Moo Toon (stewed pork) and Moo Waan (sweet pork). In addition, the zoo has a common hippo named Kha Moo (stewed pork leg).

Moo Deng's popularity has spread internationally and she has gained the attention of some professional sports teams. Fans say her name fits her lively personality. Moo Deng likes to “deng,” or bounce, and her bouncing behavior has led to countless internet memes.

FILE - Two-month-old baby hippo Moo Deng and her mother Jona are seen at the Khao Kheow Open Zoo in Chonburi province, Thailand, , Sept. 19, 2024. (AP Photo/Sakchai Lalit, File)

For example, the German soccer team FC Bayern, American basketball team Phoenix Suns and the American football team Washington Commanders have all created Moo Deng memes. The images give her interesting things to wear and put her in different human-like situations.

Atthapon, the zoo worker, told The Associated Press he was surprised the newborn pygmy hippo quickly became such a huge internet star. “I wanted people to know her,” he explained. “I wanted a lot of people to visit her, or watch her online, or leave fun comments. I never would've thought (of this),” he added.

The widespread publicity led a well-known Thai composer to write and produce a special song for Moo Deng. The lively, 50-second song is called, naturally, Moodeng. One of Thailand's biggest recording companies, GMM Music, released the song.

A music video that goes along with the song shows the baby hippo bouncing around, playing with her keeper or spending time with her mother, Jona.

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Moo Deng is now four months old. She has also been drawing big crowds at the zoo. Officials estimated the baby hippo has brought in about 3,000 to 5,000 visitors a day on average during the past few months. The zoo has been selling clothes, bedding and other products based on Moo Deng.

The zoo's director is Narongwit Chodchoi. He told the AP that the additional earnings from Moo Deng will help the zoo's breeding programs for many endangered animals, like the pygmy hippopotamus. Illegal hunting and loss of habitat threatens the animal's existence. Pygmy hippos are native to West Africa. But experts say there are only 2,000-3,000 of them left in the wild.

All four versions of the Moo Deng song are available on YouTube and on streaming services including Spotify and Apple Music.

I'm Bryan Lynn.

The Associated Press reported on this story. Bryan Lynn adapted the reports for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

bounce - v. กระด้ง, กระดอน, เด้ง

sibling - n. พี่น้อง (พี่ชาย, น้องชาย, พี่สาว, น้องสาว)

personality - n. บุคลิกภาพ, ลักษณะนิสัย

meme - n. มีม (ภาพ/วิดีโอ/ข้อความที่แพร่กระจายอย่างรวดเร็วทางอินเทอร์เน็ต)

breed - v. ผสมพันธุ์, ขยายพันธุ์

habitat - n. ถิ่นที่อยู่ตามธรรมชาติ

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What initially brought the baby hippo, Moo Deng, to widespread fame?

- A. An official song and music video release.
- B. Her lively personality, which inspired her name.
- C. Images and videos published online by zoo workers.
- D. Her unique name, which means 'bouncy pork' in Thai.

2. Where does Moo Deng primarily live?

- A. In the Thai capital, Bangkok.
- B. At Khao Kheow Open Zoo.
- C. In the wild in West Africa.
- D. At a specialized pygmy hippo sanctuary.

3. Who is primarily responsible for posting updates and 'sweet moments' of Moo Deng's life online?

- A. The zoo's director, Narongwit Chodchoi.
- B. A well-known Thai composer.
- C. Zoo worker Atthapon Nundee.
- D. Fans on social media.

4. What aspect of Moo Deng's behavior do her fans particularly enjoy watching?

- A. Her ability to swim underwater for long periods.
- B. Her interactions with professional sports teams.
- C. Her active interactions with her mother and other zoo workers.
- D. Her calm and quiet nature.

5. What is the English translation of Moo Deng's name?

- A. Stewed pork.
- B. Sweet pork.
- C. Bouncy pork.
- D. Stewed pork leg.

6. How was Moo Deng's name decided?

- A. It was chosen by the zoo staff.
- B. It was selected by a public vote on social media.
- C. It was given by a well-known Thai composer.
- D. It was randomly assigned by the zoo management.

7. What characteristic of Moo Deng has led to countless internet memes?

- A. Her preference for specific foods.
- B. Her ability to interact with fans during visits.
- C. Her lively personality and bouncing behavior.
- D. Her unique pink-cheeked appearance.

8. Which of the following professional sports teams is mentioned as having created Moo Deng memes?

- A. Los Angeles Lakers.
- B. FC Bayern.
- C. Manchester United.
- D. Boston Celtics.

9. What was zoo worker Atthapon's primary motivation for posting about Moo Deng online?

- A. To make her a global music sensation.
- B. To raise funds for the zoo's expansion.
- C. To encourage people to know her, visit her, or watch her online.
- D. To attract the attention of international sports teams.

10. What is the approximate duration of Moo Deng's official song?

- A. 30 seconds.
- B. 50 seconds.
- C. 1 minute and 30 seconds.
- D. Over 2 minutes.

11. Which major Thai recording company released Moo Deng's official song?

- A. Universal Music Thailand.
- B. Warner Music Thailand.
- C. GMM Music.
- D. Sony Music Thailand.

12. What activities are primarily shown in Moo Deng's music video?

- A. Moo Deng eating various types of food.
- B. Moo Deng interacting with her human fans.
- C. Moo Deng bouncing, playing with her keeper, and spending time with her mother.
- D. Moo Deng traveling to different locations around the world.

13. How old is Moo Deng at the time the article states her current age?

- A. Two months old.
- B. Three months old.
- C. Four months old.
- D. Five months old.

14. What is the estimated average number of daily visitors Moo Deng has attracted to the zoo?

- A. Between 1,000 and 2,000 visitors.
- B. Exactly 3,000 visitors.
- C. Between 3,000 and 5,000 visitors.
- D. More than 5,000 visitors.

15. According to the zoo's director, how will the additional earnings from Moo Deng's popularity be utilized?

- A. To fund the development of new attractions at the zoo.
- B. To support breeding programs for many endangered animals.
- C. To increase the salaries of zoo workers and staff.
- D. To produce more merchandise featuring Moo Deng.